

Practice Exercises on Evaluate the Argument Questions

1.

Although custom prosthetic bone replacements produced through a new computer-aided design process will cost more than twice as much as ordinary replacements, custom replacements should still be cost-effective. Not only will surgery and recovery time be reduced, but custom replacements should last longer, thereby reducing the need for further hospital stays.

Which of the following must be studied in order to evaluate the argument presented above?

- (A) The amount of time a patient spends in surgery versus the amount of time spent recovering from surgery
- (B) The amount by which the cost of producing custom replacements has declined with the introduction of the new technique for producing them
- (C) The degree to which the use of custom replacements is likely to reduce the need for repeat surgery when compared with the use of ordinary replacements
- (D) The degree to which custom replacements produced with the new technique are more carefully manufactured than are ordinary replacements
- (E) The amount by which custom replacements produced with the new technique will drop in cost as the production procedures become standardized and applicable on a larger scale

2.

In the past the country of Malvernia has relied heavily on imported oil. Malvernia recently implemented a program to convert heating systems from oil to natural gas. Malvernia currently produces more natural gas each year than it uses, and oil production in Malvernian oil fields is increasing at a steady pace. If these trends in fuel production and usage continue, therefore, Malvernian reliance on foreign sources for fuel is likely to decline soon.

Which of the following would it be most useful to establish in evaluating the argument?

- (A) When, if ever, will production of oil in Malvernia outstrip production of natural gas?
- (B) Is Malvernia among the countries that rely most on imported oil?
- (C) What proportion of Malvernia's total energy needs is met by hydroelectric, solar, and nuclear power?
- (D) Is the amount of oil used each year in Malvernia for generating electricity and fuel for transportation increasing?
- (E) Have any existing oil-burning heating systems in Malvernia already been converted to natural-gas-burning heating systems?

3.

Community activist: If Morganville wants to keep its central shopping district healthy, it should prevent the opening of a huge SaveAll discount department store on the outskirts of Morganville. Records from other small towns show that whenever SaveAll has opened a store outside the central shopping district of a small town, within five years the town has experienced the bankruptcies of more than a quarter of the stores in the shopping district.

The answer to which of the following would be most useful for evaluating the community activist's reasoning?

- (A) Have community activists in other towns successfully campaigned against the opening of a SaveAll store on the outskirts of their towns?
- (B) Do a large percentage of the residents of Morganville currently do almost all of their shopping at stores in Morganville?
- (C) In towns with healthy central shopping districts, what proportion of the stores in those districts suffer bankruptcy during a typical five-year period?
- (D) What proportion of the employees at the SaveAll store on the outskirts of Morganville will be drawn from Morganville?
- (E) Do newly opened SaveAll stores ever lose money during their first five years of operation?

4.

Books about architectural works, unless they are not intended for a general audience, ought to include discussions of both the utility and the aesthetic appeal of each of the buildings they consider. If they do not, they are flawed. Morton's book on Italian Baroque palaces describes these palaces' functional aspects, but fails to mention that the main hall of a palace he discusses at length has a ceiling that is one of the truly breathtaking masterpieces of Western art.

If the statements above are true, it would be necessary to establish which one of the following in order to conclude that Morton's book is flawed?

- (A) Morton's description of the palaces' utility is inaccurate.
- (B) Morton's book does not discuss aspects of the palaces other than utility and aesthetic appeal.
- (C) Morton's book is intended for a general audience.
- (D) The passage discussing the palace plays a very important role in helping to establish the overall argument of Morton's book.
- (E) The palace discussed at length is one of the most aesthetically important of those treated in Morton's book.

5.

Raising the tax rate on essential goods—a traditional means of increasing government revenues—invariably turns low- and middle-income taxpayers against the government. Hence government officials have proposed adding a new tax on purchases of luxury items such as yachts, private planes, jewels, and furs. The officials claim that this tax will result in a substantial increase in government revenues while affecting only the wealthy individuals and corporations who can afford to purchase such items.

The answer to which one of the following questions would be most relevant in evaluating the accuracy of the government officials' prediction?

- (A) Will luxury goods be taxed at a higher rate than that at which essential goods are currently taxed?
- (B) Will the revenues generated by the proposed tax be comparable to those that are currently being generated by taxes on essential goods?
- (C) Will sales of the luxury items subject to the proposed tax occur at current rates once the proposed tax on luxury items has been passed?
- (D) Will the proposed tax on luxury items win support for the government in the eyes of low- and middle-income taxpayers?
- (E) Will purchases of luxury items by corporations account for more of the revenue generated by the proposed tax than will purchases of luxury items by wealthy individuals?